Apoptosis

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/46263511.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra)

Characters:
Entrapta (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Hanahaki but it's Beast Island nightmare plants, Body Horror, Illness, Eventual Smut, Romance, Angst, the princesses are trying to be better friends, Beast Island nightmare vines, Entrapta gets an apology, No ‘violence’ here per se but pretty serious injury/illness so I’m using that warning tag, Angst with a Happy Ending, Reunion Sex

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Apoptosis

by Madgirlmuahaha

Summary

After being rescued from Beast Island by the princess alliance, Entrapta finds herself facing a new danger taking hold of her body.

You can take the princess out of Beast Island, but you can't take Beast Island out of the princess.

Notes

AU in which Scorpia and Glimmer join the Beast Island rescue mission instead of setting off the apocalypse machine that is the Heart of Etheria.

I'm not super familiar with the Hanahaki trope, I've never really been interested in reading it and I don't know how it's usually written, but it caught my attention as a plot bunny and this is my take on it, complete with a hearty dose of body horror and eventual smut!

Not fine

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Entrapta stared at herself in the pool of water. The more she stared, the less real it felt, like any second the reflection would shift and change to the vine-covered landscape of Beast Island and there'd be a thousand tiny eyes peering out at her, waiting to pounce.

The face that stared back at her certainly looked more like it belonged back in Beast Island than in Bright Moon. She was a raggedy, filthy, anxious wreck who was tainting the pristine, serene environment of Bright Moon just by existing.

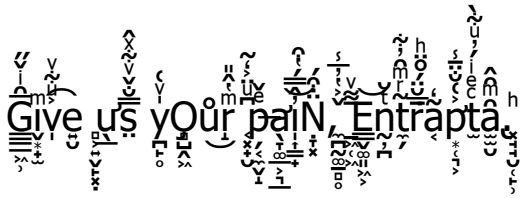
As she peeled away layers of tattered clothing, she kept her eyes trained on the reflection in front of her. There was a part of her that was very small and very scared that wasn't quite ready to inspect the damage done to her actual physical body, but keeping her attention on the reflection allowed her to process the data without falling apart.

There were old bruises and scrapes all over her arms and legs. A nick in her right eyebrow from that time a mantisaur's razor-sharp blades hacked through her welding mask. The giant, jagged burn mark on her back ached as the clean water washed over it, stripping away layers of dirt and old blood and exposing the tender, broken skin underneath.

When her hair became too waterlogged to be useful, Entrapta proceeded with a robotic calmness, forcing her tired, calloused hands to scrub away at the evidence of what the island had done to her. She scrubbed with all her strength, completely disregarding the pain prickling the surface of her skin, so long as it all washed away.

It wasn't enough.

Her entire body shuddered as something wriggled from the inside. Tiny vein-like tendrils manifested underneath the outermost layer of her skin, visible for a brief moment before vanishing again. Like little vines invading her body, sprouting around and between her internal organs and claiming her body as its home. No amount of scrubbing could strip away the mark the island had made on her.



Entrapta dunked her head under the water, shocking her system just enough to keep the voices at bay. The thing invading her body eased its hold around her trachea, allowing her to exhale in a moment of hard-fought relief.

She was in Bright Moon. She was among friends. She was safe. Whatever was going on inside of her body, she could fix it.

She just needed a little bit more time.

Scorpia was the first to visit that night. She knocked on the door with her tail, balancing a tray of tiny bowls filled with plain broth and carbonated lemonade on her pincers.

“A special request to the kitchen,” Scorpia offered, carefully setting the tray down on the makeshift worktable Entrapta had fashioned out of some metal sheeting she’d found in a maintenance closet. “I managed to talk them down from feeding you anything too rich. The food here made me sick the first few days I was staying with them. Horde survival training tells me it’s probably better to start simple, with plenty of electrolytes.”

Entrapta grunted in acknowledgement without looking up from her datapad or removing her mask. Words were a precious currency with her body in such a variable state; she needed to make the most of her energy before the vines woke up again. She took three sips from one of the teacup-sized portions before a wave of nausea swept away what little appetite she had.

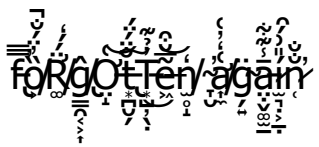
Scorpia peered over her shoulder. “Whatcha working on?”

“Data.”

Evidently, that wasn’t an adequate response for Scorpia, as she fidgeted in a manner that Entrapta mentally cross-referenced as extreme discomfort. “Ask Bow,” Entrapta mumbled, gesturing to the door with a pigtail.

A faint whimper escaped from Scorpia. “You’re still mad at me, aren’t you? Oh my gosh, I knew it! Not that I blame you or anything—you have every right to feel the way you do, and I’d give me the silent treatment too if things were the other way around. I’ll go if you want to be left alone, I just—I’ve been a really, really bad friend to you, and I’d really like to try to be a better one. But only if you’re okay with it!”

The words spilled out in a jumbled mess, making Entrapta’s head spin with a sudden deluge of emotional information. She felt her head tighten, like an elastic band wrapped around her forehead, and closed her eyes to tune out the too-bright lights of her borrowed room.



“I’m not mad at you,” Entrapta said, hoping that her curtness wouldn’t be taken as anger. She didn’t have the energy anymore to be angry. Even if she did, it wasn’t as if she was in any position

to act upon it. She still felt uneasy about her status with the other princesses, and almost everything she owned was still under Horde control.

"But you're so quiet! This isn't like you, especially not when it comes to science stuff." A look of horror flashed across Scorpia's face. "Beast Island did something that broke you, didn't it? And it's my fault."

"I don't want to talk about it," Entrapta snapped from behind her mask. As she felt the pressure building in her temples, she understood a little bit better why Hordak had always been so grumpy whenever his condition flared up. "If you want to be a better friend, tell me what happened after the portal."

Scorpia settled on an overstuffed plush cushion. The two former Horde princesses shared a moment of nostalgia for a simpler time before the portal, when Scorpia would barge into Entrapta's storage closet-turned-laboratory and spend hours together swapping gossip about who broke into the commissary for extra ration bars and how cute Hordak's ears were whenever he got flustered.

"Things got really bad really fast without you," Scorpia confessed. "Catra was losing it. I know I've made excuses for her before, but this was something else. It's like she forgot we were people. We were just pawns for her to command."

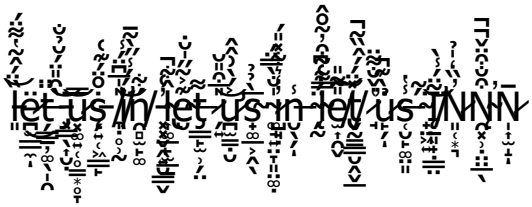
"And… Hordak?"

"He didn't know what happened to you. I don't know what Catra told him, but he believed her. I wanted to say something, anything, but for all I know, he'd believe her over me and toss me in jail. I just had to get out of there."

Entrapta nodded, a lump forming in her throat. "You waited."

Scorpia opened her mouth to try to respond, then abandoned her words and scooped the smaller woman up in one of her signature

full-body hugs. “I’m so, so sorry, and I’m so glad that you’re still alive.”



Entrapta buried her head into her friend’s chest, removing her mask for the first time since arriving in Bright Moon, and sobbed. She released months of pent-up emotions, screaming and crying until her face was dripping in sweat, tears, and mucus. She cried until her entire body hurt, heaving from the tightness in her chest and helpless to alleviate it. Scorpia’s eyes widened as Entrapta gasped for breath between violent sobs, struggling to find air and then doubling over in painful convulsions.

Two surprisingly gentle pincers stopped Entrapta’s body from hitting the ground as she collapsed into spasms, the parasitic vines inside of her constricting around her stomach and violently expelling a noxious combination of broth, bile, and tiny flecks of vegetative matter. The foul mixture soiled Entrapta’s clean clothes and dribbled down the crimson carapace of her companion.

Instead of reacting with disgust, Scorpia simply met her with pure concern. “I’m getting Adora.”

“M’ fine, I just need some time…” Entrapta’s words slurred together as the vomit-soaked floor seemed more and more attractive as a location for a spontaneous nap.

“You are absolutely not fine! You’re even farther from ‘fine’ than I thought you were!”

Before Entrapta could muster out a response, everything went black.

Chapter End Notes

Evil Vine lines:

- Give us your pain, Entrapta.

- Forgotten again

- Let us in, let us in, let us in

Troubleshooting

Chapter Summary

> The Princesses try their best to figure out what's wrong with Entrapta.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

" —It's gotta be more than just the vines, right? We were all exposed to them on the rescue mission, but none of the rest of us brought it back."

"She was out there for a really long time. More opportunity for infection?"

"So was my dad, and he's not sick. Not like this."

Entrapta regained consciousness to one of her least favorite noises: other people talking about her, right in front of her. At least they could show her the courtesy of leaving the room before they talked behind her back.

Something cold and sharp itched against her arm. As she tried to scratch it off, four pairs of hands crowded around her and grabbed at her arms. Her head was still too fuzzy to register everything around her. Hair moved of its own autonomy, reflexively grappling anything around her and curling up into a defensive position as too many voices yelled out at her.

"IV! It's just fluids, Entrapta!" A voice that she recognized as Bow's called out.

She felt for the medical tape with her fingers. In her lingering drowsiness, every small movement felt like swimming through syrup, fighting to get her muscles to cooperate with her. She felt

the little plastic clips and medical tubing and picked at the tape fastening it all to her skin.

“Can you keep it on for just a little longer?” Scorpia’s voice, this time. “You’re severely dehydrated, and you haven’t been able to keep anything down orally.”

Entrapta stopped picking at the tape and lolled her head back on her pillow, relaxing her hair and releasing everybody who’d been unfortunate enough to be within range of its grip.

“Good to know that at least the hair’s awake,” Mermista said. Entrapta couldn’t muster the energy to open her eyes, but she could hear the sea princess roll her eyes. “I’m going to take a wild guess and say that’s your way of asking for personal space?”

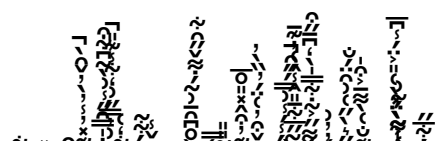
Entrapta’s head felt too heavy to give any sort of nonverbal response, so she simply uttered a lethargic *, “Mhm.”*

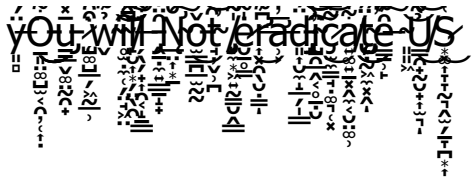
“Cool beans. If anybody needs me, I’ll be chilling in my guest room, having fun not getting strangled to death.”

Multiple sets of footsteps shuffled out of the room. Entrapta could still feel people staring at her, but at least the atmosphere wasn’t quite so stifling. She cracked her eyes open just enough to catch a glimpse of bright red sitting by her bed. “How do you feel?” Scorpia asked softly.

“Like shit.” Entrapta grimaced at the gritty sensation on her tongue.

Adora approached her, gripping the hilt of her sword in one hand and holding her other hand up in a position of surrender, warily eyeing the purple tendrils of hair. “I’m going to put my hand on your shoulder and try to heal whatever’s hurting you, is that okay?”





“I—I think so,” Entrapta mumbled. “Just… be careful.”

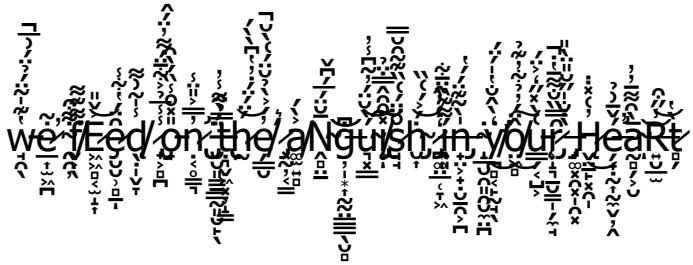
With a flash of bright light, She-Ra stood before her, ever the paragon of virtue and nobility. An overwhelming warmth radiated from her hand, spreading outward through Entrapta’s body with a faint tingling sensation that wasn’t entirely unpleasant but still felt strange.

As the heat spread to her lungs and stomach and heart, the thing creeping inside of her seized up, squeezing around her organs and sending sharp rays of pain that sent her doubling over in a fetal position.

Adora gasped, but kept her hand firmly on Entrapta’s shoulder. She closed her eyes and inhaled deeply, trying to focus all of her magical energy on the healing spell.

Tiny little veins popped from beneath the surface of Entrapta’s skin. They slithered around with purpose, creeping ever closer to the source of the healing magic, until it finally made contact with Adora’s fingers through the surface of Entrapta’s skin.





Adora cried out in shock and fell back from the contact, dropping her sword and tumbling to the floor in a heap of panic. Entrapta's lungs gave out on her, hacking and wheezing and sending a mess of phlegm and blood out of her throat. Scorpia immediately leapt to her side and started rubbing gentle circles on her back with the smooth, blunt side of her pincer.

When Entrapta finally caught her breath enough to look at the young Princess of Power, she saw a deep, overwhelming existential fear reflected in those stormy blue eyes. "You heard it too, didn't you?" She wheezed, her throat still raw from the coughing attack.

Adora nodded, staring down at her hands. "She-Ra's healing… I don't know why it's not working. But those voices… how often does that happen to you?"

"Multiple times per hour," Entrapta rasped bluntly. "Up to twelve times per hour during active hours, but the rate during resting hours is still inconclusive. The pathogen follows some sort of biological clock loosely correlated with my own, but I haven't been able to sleep much." She reached for her datapad with a pigtail. "I've been trying to dig up any data about Beast Island flora and fauna from the data modules I recovered from the abandoned research network. Unfortunately, it seems this species mutated into its current form sometime in the thousand years since the last network update. Very inconvenient for my research."

Adora and Scorpia exchanged a look, seeming taken aback by Entrapta's very matter-of-fact approach to her own illness. Entrapta kept her eyes glued to her datapad. Someone had taken her mask off while she was out cold, and she didn't appreciate the nonverbal indication that she was reacting to things in the 'wrong way'. If she didn't keep her mind trained on this as a research project, her restless brain would take her train of thought down avenues that were considerably more terrifying than some old data left behind by the First Ones.

Perfuma materialized from somewhere behind Scorpia. Apparently, she'd been in the room the whole time, keeping a safe distance from Entrapta's hair after the earlier incident. She looked closely at the grotesque glob of mucus and blood that had been horked up onto the blanket and raised an eyebrow at Entrapta. "Can I…?"

With a halfhearted shrug of approval from the emotionally exhausted tech princess, Perfuma probed the bloody snot ball with her thin, delicate fingers, without hesitating or flinching. After several seconds of searching, she extracted something pale and paper-thin from the goop. She folded it into a tissue, trying to get as much gunk off of the foreign object as possible. When it was clear enough, Perfuma held it up to the light to inspect the details.

A tiny, perfectly formed five-petal blossom lay in her hands, still sticky with Entrapta's bodily fluids.

With this discovery, Perfuma paced circles around the room, anxiously tugging at the flowers braided into her hair. "Oh no. Oh, this is bad. This is really, really, bad. It's blooming! You guys, it's blooming!" She halted her pacing just long enough to shake Adora and Scorpia by the shoulder. "Oh my goodness—you guys! Don't you get it? It's blooming!"

Scorpia shrugged awkwardly. "It means it's a plant making her sick, right? Does that mean you can help?"

"Maybe. I don't know. I want to, but I—oh goodness," Perfuma bit at her nails as she studied Entrapta sitting in her bed. "We don't have much time. I need to consult something in Plumeria, I'll be right back!" Without any further explanation, Perfuma dashed out of Entrapta's room to hunt down Glimmer.

Entrapta finally looked up from her datapad back at the two remaining princesses in her room. A deep, cold feeling settled in the pit of her stomach as she tried to make sense of Perfuma's reaction.

It was blooming. The thing inside of her had survived Adora's attempt to exorcize it. Not only was it surviving within her, it was *thriving.* It was propagating itself. It had incubated within her body long enough to form complex reproductive structures. How much longer would she have until the thing invading her body had reached its fully mature state? How much of her body would be left alive?

She picked at the tape fastening the IV to her arm, dreading that it didn't matter anyway, because any nutrients her body tried to absorb would be claimed by the nightmarish parasite crawling within every crevice of her body.



Scorpia stayed by her side while Adora left to grab extra blankets and pillows. They both insisted on staying in Entrapta's room, taking turns to sleep to keep watch just in case her condition took another turn for the worse. Entrapta thought it was an overreaction and felt mildly annoyed by the gesture, she'd always had difficulty falling asleep around other people and believed the efforts to be futile. Their interventions so far hadn't done much to stabilize her.

Well, there was *one* person she'd felt comfortable enough around to fall asleep near, but Bright Moon was a far cry from the cozy industrial ambiance of the Sanctum, and as much as she appreciated the attention of her two ex-Horde friends, neither could compare to her lab partner.

Entrapta buried herself back in her datapad while the well-meaning but ultimately tiresome people around her continued to act for her, without her.

Chapter End Notes

Evil vine messages:

- You will not eradicate us

-O daughter of the ancient ones, follow our call
-We feed on the anguish in your heart

-Let our mercy bloom within

:) idk if "enjoy" is the right word here, but I hope y'all are enjoying the ride so far! Comments keep the muse fed!

Prognosis

Chapter Summary

> An old Plumerian legend sheds light on the parasitic disease infecting Entrapta.

Chapter Notes

> I know I used archive warnings and there's an E rating here, but just as a heads up there's a detailed description of a panic attack here and a lot of death/mortality talk. Fun stuff!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was a few hours later when Perfuma returned, clutching a weathered scroll close to her heart. Entrapta didn't mind the sudden interruption, she hadn't been able to sleep more than an hour or two at a time, anyway.

"I know it's not exactly scientific, but there's an old Plumerian legend we have about a plant that blooms in the hearts of those suffering from unrequited love," Perfuma solemnly unraveled her scroll, revealing a text in ancient Plumerian script adorned with tendrils of ivy and pale five-petaled blossoms, encompassing an illustration of a woman adorned in gold and green vestments with tree roots and branches growing out from her limbs.

"Hundreds of years ago, a Plumerian queen befriended a princess visiting from a neighboring territory and fell in love with her. But it was known that the princess had promised her heart to another in her homeland, and the queen never confessed her feelings, fearing for their friendship and political alliance. As she watched her love return home and begin a happy life with someone else, the queen's unspoken feelings formed a seed of grief that planted within her heart.

With each day that she spent yearning for a love that could never be, the seed sprouted and grew within her body, the roots and

branches overtaking her as she tried to live with the pain. Finally, the princess's wedding day came, but the queen could not bring herself to attend her beloved friend's ceremony. The queen found a hilltop overlooking the neighboring territory and sat down to rest for the last time, unable to move with the realization that it was far too late to act upon her feelings. She succumbed to the plant growing within her, letting it consume her completely and sprout around her as a tree, forever looking upon the woman she loved, but without any voice to tell her or any hands to touch her."

Perfuma fidgeted with the faded corners of the scroll. "It's not a very happy story," she admitted, "But it's the best lead I have in identifying it. It's more than just a fairytale, we have records of outbreaks in other people, but it only pops up in the wild during rare seasons with a particularly strong swell of magic in the environment, just like most other magic plants. And, well, it's been several decades since we've had one of those, maybe even centuries.* At least, that's how it's been in Plumeria."

"Fascinating," Entrapta exhaled shakily, closely studying the details of the Plumerian scroll. She felt a melancholy sort of solidarity with the green and gold queen entrapped by the branches of the parasitic tree, another soul who understood the pain of having her own body taken from her control, of knowing that something inside of you was thriving even as you were dying.

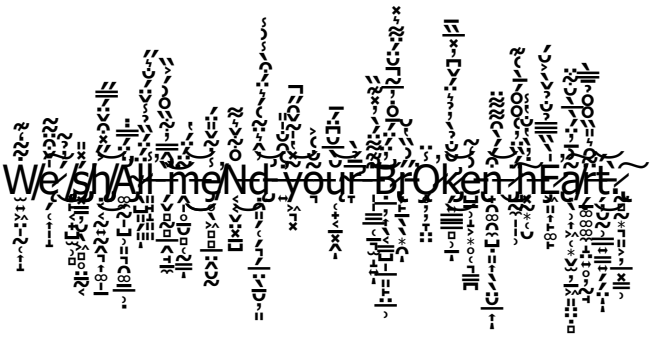
Perfuma's story was a legend, most likely either a dramatization of historical events or a consolidation of multiple accounts into a single streamlined tale, and not a literal depiction of the past. Still, Entrapta couldn't help but wonder why the ancient queen hadn't at least said something about her feelings even when she knew she was dying. Sure, maybe it would have been too late, but why bring those feelings to the grave when withholding them brought so much pain?

Adora and Scorpia were both awake and attentive by now. Scorpia looked down at the Sword of Power with a questioning look. "Now that we know what it might be, do you think we should try another healing spell?"

“No!” Entrapta and Adora exclaimed simultaneously.

“It’s possible that the First Ones took a sample of this plant to the Beast Island research facility while it was still active, to study its unique magical and pathologic properties,” Entrapta mused out loud, reaching for her datapad. “If that’s the case, then when it was abandoned, those samples could’ve cross-bred with the local flora and integrated with the defunct technology on the island, creating a uniquely dangerous sub-species distinct from the magical plant of Plumerian folklore.”

“We call it *Prunus cardia,* the Heartbreak Blossom,” Perfuma said softly.



Finally armed with a proper name, Entrapta pulled Adora closer with her hair to huddle over the recovered First One’s data as an assistant translator. Thirty minutes painstakingly ticked by, precious time spent scrolling and manually inputting complex strings of data to get some sort of hit.

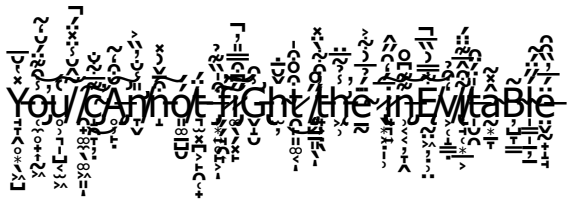
There had to be information about it. There had to be some sort of weakness to this thing that she could exploit, some sort of chemical vulnerability or obscure magical spell. Maybe the current mutation had developed so far beyond *Prunus cardia* that it would no longer have the same vulnerabilities, but at least it would be a start in understanding what this monstrosity was and how to eradicate it. Or, if eradicating it wasn’t feasible, how to live with it without letting it dominate her life.

Entrapta thought of her lab partner, of the genetic condition that had made his life difficult since the day he'd been decanted, and the armor she'd made to help improve his quality of life. It hadn't been perfect, but it made a world of difference for him. With the upgraded armor, Hordak carried himself with a whole new sense of confidence that she couldn't help but feel overjoyed at.

"There," Adora poked at the screen. " *Prunus cardia,* that's the entry."

A string of First Ones characters that Entrapta recognized as numbers scrolled across the screen. "Can you decipher it?"

The younger woman blinked rapidly, trying to process the raw information. "It looks like… mortality rates? Eighty percent within three weeks of infection… rapid progression… ah! There's a treatment listed here. 'Adequate concentration of oxytocin and serotonin are correlated with favorable outcomes. Treatment within the first few days of showing symptoms is crucial for patient survival. All known cases of patients abstaining from treatment have led to a complete breakdown of organ systems within one month."



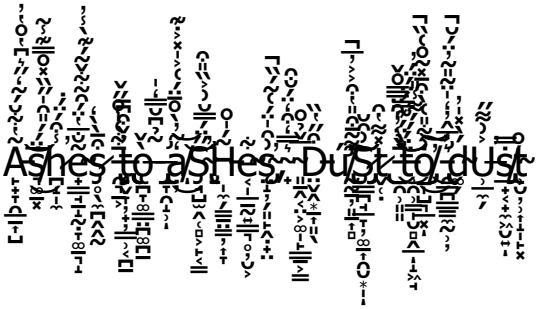
A suffocating silence came over the room, the only sound being the voices crowding in Entrapta's head.

A deep, hungering emptiness formed in the pit of her stomach. Finally, she had the science behind this sickness. She knew its name and its history and its mortality rate, she knew what was needed to cure it, and what would happen if it was allowed to continue wreaking havoc on her body.

One month. That’s how much time she had. One month, counting from the first seconds of infection.

Entrapta’s head spun, trying to put all the math together. Two hundred and eighty-three days on Beast Island, three days so far in Bright Moon. When had the infection taken hold of her? When did the voices start? Everything on Beast Island had blurred together in a nightmarish cacophony of fear and misery, punctuated only with scant few moments of technological discovery. Day 282 had blended into the same miasma of terrifying memories as Day 3 or Day 62. She didn’t even have any audio logs to consult. She’d given up trying to document her experience on Beast Island within the first few weeks. Documenting took too much valuable energy that she’d needed just to survive, and there wasn’t much going on that she wanted to retain memories about.

Short, gasping breaths escaped from her as she tried to wrap her brain around the temporal reality of her situation. How many more days would it be? Twenty was a generous estimation if the pathogen had taken root in her just a few days before the Princess Alliance had come for her. Her body was already rejecting sleep and nutrition. The pathogen was blooming.



Scorpia tried to coach her through breathing exercises, but Entrapta’s body wouldn’t cooperate. Her heart pounded in her ears, lungs heaving for dear life despite the piercing pain brought with each breath. She was stuck in a loop, hyperventilating while her grip on reality faded away.

The parasite inside of Entrapta remained quiet. She could feel it, wriggling around her veins and organs, but it didn't move or lurch or squeeze her until her body gave out again. It just sat in her body, taking up space, lying in wait.

Why couldn't it just get it over with already? If she was already doomed, why did it have to torture her like this, leave her anxious and spiraling about when it would finally end her?

Ungloved fingers registered the sensation of something smooth and hard. They ran back and forth across the surface of Scorpia's pincers in a trance-like motion as her brain rebooted and her breathing evened out, grounding Entrapta back into her body and turning her focus to a physical sensation that wasn't the parasite lurking inside of her.

Adora looked at her remorsefully, clearly blaming herself for unintentionally triggering this reaction. "I–I'm not a doctor, I bet it's not as bad as what I said. There's probably another article buried in there that I missed. I could be mistranslating something, too."

"Yeah," Scorpia chimed in hesitantly, "And it's not like we know for sure that it's the Heartbreak Blossom Perfuma knows about. You said it's a mutation, right? It could be a less deadly version. Maybe."

Neither of them seemed to have any confidence in their reassurances. Adora's translation had been as accurate as it could be, and not even Scorpia was naive enough to earnestly believe that a Beast Island subspecies of an already lethal magical plant was likely to be less dangerous than its predecessor.

"I'm dying."

Entrapta heard the words ring out in her voice, but it didn't feel like her lips saying them. It wasn't a cry of despair or plea for pity, just a simple, blunt observation of the facts at hand. One more data point to add to the chart.

Perfuma grazed her fingers over the illustration of the Plumerian queen. "Yes. Right now, at least," she spoke in a calm, poised cadence that Entrapta may have once found irritating, but now she appreciated the validation of her mortality without any hint of pity or denial. "There may yet be hope. Please excuse me if this is a bit too invasive, but… uh…"

Perfuma looked away with a blush, humming and anxiously twisting the stem of a yellow flower around her finger. Entrapta snorted at her embarrassment. So Entrapta's impending death wasn't an awkward topic to talk about, but *this* was?

"Was there a… um, *special someone* you were involved with in the Horde?" Perfuma finally blurted out. "Or before the Horde. Anyone, really. A lover, or a crush, or a friends-with-benefits type of thing where feelings might've been involved? Because if there is someone special, um, the Heartbreak Blossom's magic can be cured with… um, 'love stuff'."

'Love stuff' was a frustratingly vague and incredibly unscientific description, but poor Perfuma looked like she'd combust from embarrassment if questioned about the specifics.

"So, if we can get in contact with this special someone and arrange some, um, *alone time* with them, that might be enough to save you from becoming a tree like in the story. Not that there's anything wrong with being a tree! Some of my best friends are trees," Perfuma stammered, "But for you, Entrapta? No offense, but you don't have the right mystic vibrations to make for a very happy tree. Which is a good thing, because we're all trying to stop you from becoming a tree, right?"

"You spent most of your time in the Fright Zone working, didn't you?" Scorpia mused, "I don't remember hearing much about other people except maybe— *oh!"* She swiveled her head so suddenly, she nearly headbutt Entrapta. "I KNEW IT! I knew you guys were close, but I didn't want to probe! Why didn't you tell me?"

“I’ve been a little bit preoccupied since the portal incident, with the whole ‘collapsing of reality’ and ‘stranded on Beast Island’ thing!” Entrapta snapped back.

Scorpia let out a high-pitched whine. “I need details!”

Adora’s face flushed in realization. “Wait, so the ‘LUVD’ thing was on purpose?”

“So there is someone special!” Perfuma beamed joyfully. “I was a little worried, just because you seem to connect with robots more than people. Not that I should be one to judge, I feel the same way about plants, but I’m glad that you’ve had someone who sparks joy for you! Who do we need to reach out to?”

The atmosphere in the room had taken a complete shift since they’d realized how limited Entrapta’s time was. It didn’t feel like a matter of life and death so much as a bubbly, overeager gossip session between female friends. The parasite dwelling within her fortunately remained dormant—or unfortunately, as another episode would’ve made for a convenient way out of this incredibly personal conversation. She almost preferred the panic attack to the flustered, simmering sensations brewing in her gut under the expectant gazes of her friends, just to keep the attention away from the secrets of her heart.

Entrapta swallowed the lump forming in her throat. “I need my lab partner.”

Before anybody could react further, a knock on the door interrupted them.

“Her Highness, Queen Glimmer, has called for a meeting of the Princess Alliance. All members who are able to are requested to attend, ex-Horde company included.”

Chapter End Notes

Even more evil vine lines!

- We shall mend your broken heart

- You cannot fight the inevitable

- Ashes to ashes, dust to dust

Hanahaki is, to my knowledge, usually portrayed as cherry blossoms. So naturally I stole the family name Prunus from irl cherry blossoms, paired it with cardia meaning “heart”, and named this nightmare fantasy plant Prunus cardia. Just in time for spring!

*In Plumeria, these rare seasons of particularly strong magical swells are called the Bloom. Ever since the Heart of Etheria began stockpiling magic energy, Blooms have happened less and less frequently, with less magical energy in the natural environment to go around. These events can be tracked by analyzing the rings of trees in areas affected by the Bloom. Smaller swells still occur occasionally, but the last true Bloom in Plumeria occurred 120 years ago. “Once in a true Bloom” is a hyperbolic cultural phrase used in Plumeria to express the rarity of an event.

None of that has much relevance to the rest of this story, but I spent too much brainpower and creativity coming up with that lore to not include it somewhere.

A Diplomatic Approach

Chapter Summary

> Entrapta wants to go home. Micah deserves a break. Shadow Weaver ruins everything.

Chapter Notes

> A little bit less body horror with this one, but Shadow Weaver opens her mouth so hopefully that makes up for it.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

As soon as she stepped into the gleaming conference room for the Alliance meeting, Entrapta immediately regretted leaving her bed. The parasite inside of her remained still, giving her a rare opportunity to be on her feet and productive until it decided to strike again, but gracefully navigating a bright, echoey room full of former friends-turned-enemies (or was it enemies-turned-friends now?) was not what she wanted to expend her energy on.

Glimmer widened her eyes at the tech princess's entrance. "You're… feeling better?" The young queen couldn't mask the doubt in her voice as she glanced up and down Entrapta's body. Entrapta wondered if she could sense the thing lurking underneath her skin, or if it was somehow visible even from Glimmer's seat across the room.

"I was invited," Entrapta replied bluntly from behind her mask.

The young queen nodded. "Right. Yes, you were. If you're up to it, then having you on board makes our job a little bit easier." Glimmer gestured with a cloud of sparkles to an empty chair next to Scorpia's.

No matter how many times she'd been told about the late queen's disappearance into the defunct portal's vortex, Entrapta could not quite see Glimmer as more than a child pretending to be in a

position of authority. Still, she took the seat assigned to her without remarking. She did not envy Glimmer's position, nor could she forget that part of the responsibility for that tragedy fell on her own shoulders.

"I'm going to skip the formalities and get right to it," Glimmer dictated calmly, her fingers clenching into fists. "The Horde's closing in on us. They already have control over the mountains through Dryl, they've destroyed most of Salineas and taken our sea routes, and even with the natural magic barriers of the Whispering Woods, their tech has advanced to the point where they've been able to brute-force their way through."

Entrapta felt an uncomfortable amount of attention directed at her, silently reminding her that she was responsible for at least the first of those issues, and likely the third. She couldn't help but wonder if Hordak had found and perfected her thaumaturgical positioning devices to help navigate through the ever-changing mystical landscape of the Whispering Woods, or if he'd simply repurposed the quantum stabilization software that they'd developed together for the portal project to temporarily stop the forest from shifting around.

"I keep telling you guys, they don't have enough manpower left to keep up this pressure for any longer than the next few weeks," Scorpia spoke up. "If you guys can just wait it out until then–"

"My city is *on fire,* " Mermista snapped, slamming her hand down on the table. "All they care about is beating us into submission. We can't afford to wait until—what? They just get tired and go home?"

"They're people too!" Scorpia insisted, "Tired, overworked, undervalued people. Geez, for a bunch of folks who claim to be all about freedom and love, you sure seem to forget that those armored troops you're fighting have names and faces and lives."

"Yeah, well, so do the thousands of Salinean citizens who've lost their homes and lives in this shitshow, so *excuse me* for coming

up a little short on empathy," Mermista seethed.

Glimmer pounded her staff down to call for order. "Let's win the war first, then we can decide on the whole 'showing mercy to the enemies who have destroyed everything we know and love' thing, okay?"

Mermista sat back in her seat with a bitter huff as Scorpia glanced back at Entrapta with wide, fearful eyes. With the incredibly tense anti-Horde atmosphere in the room, it was impossible to imagine that the other princesses in the alliance would be supportive of the course of action that would need to be taken to keep Entrapta from dying a slow, horrible death.

Perfuma cleared her throat and raised her hand. "I know we're in a precarious situation, but I'd like to remind everybody that diplomacy is still an option—"

A collective groan rippled out.

"A gift basket isn't going to help us!" Frosta piped up. "Unless there's a bomb hidden in it. That might actually be cool."

Perfuma giggled nervously. "Oh, no, I wasn't thinking about bombs. Just some flowers and snacks and things. Though bath bombs might be a nice addition!"

"Oh, sure, let's add some chocolates and handmade soaps while we're at it, I'm sure they'll be too busy pampering themselves to commit acts of mass destruction," Mermista sniped back. "It's a little late for gift baskets, isn't it?"

"We won't know unless we try! And, um," Perfuma sent a sideways glance over to Entrapta. "There's something else going on that we urgently need to discuss first. Right, Entrapta?"

Entrapta felt the full weight of everyone's attention come down on her. She felt her heart racing and stomach clenching up. What were they expecting from her?

“I need to go home,” Entrapta finally said in a small, raspy voice.

Glimmer sighed. “Dryl’s still under Horde control, we can’t—”

“I’ll build whatever you need me to, but I need my tools and materials. I’m the one who helped build the tech you’re fighting against, I can make something to bring it all down.” The words came out impassively, barely louder than a whisper.

Entrapta’s heart lurched at the mere thought of turning against her own creations, the hundreds of bots that she’d upgraded and re-designed with her lab partner. They were like her children—beautiful, deadly children made of two tons of durasteel and armed with the finest lasers on the planet. But if this is what it took to help her get home…

“Our last mission in Dryl ended up in disaster, and the Horde’s concentrated their forces there since then,” Glimmer said.

“Send a request for a temporary cease-fire to renegotiate the occupation of Dryl. We weren’t conquered, we were in alliance together, and I still have dominion over my territory. H— *Lord* Hordak has always honored my authority in Drylian affairs. At least, during our… partnership.”

Mermista scoffed. “You want us to just ask him really nicely? Oh, pretty please don’t kill us, Mr. Lord Hordak. We just want to have a quick visit to build a bunch of murderbots to destroy your evil army. I didn’t think anything could top Perfuma’s gift baskets, but here we fucking are!”

“I still think the gift basket idea should be on the table!” Perfuma cried out, and the room erupted into another round of heated arguments.

“Being nice doesn’t work when we’re fighting literal evil!”

“Not all Hordesmen are bad!”

“I’m gonna punch that party-pooper in her stupid—“

"If you'd just listen to me!"

"Maybe if you had something worth saying?"

A chill ran through the room as a shadowy figure manifested behind Glimmer's throne, dimming the lights with her mere presence. A silky-smooth voice rang out over the chaos, speaking clear as a bell as everybody else hushed.

"As much as I'd love to agree that Lord Hordak is as easy to negotiate with as a brick wall, there's one key thing you're all missing," Shadow Weaver drawled, extending a slender finger right at Entrapta. "He'll listen to *her* , in ways that he never listened to me. I spent decades trying to twist his will to my own ends, but *you*— oh, you lovely little young thing, you had him wrapped around your finger within a matter of days. Devotion like that doesn't come cheap. It'd be a waste not to take advantage of it."

Entrapta's chest tightened. Sure, maybe the words coming from the witch's mouth were the closest thing to compliments she'd ever heard Shadow Weaver say, but they were weighed down with a heavy tone that made her feel filthy, like there was something deeply wrong and exploitative with the bond she'd had with her lab partner.

"Of course, I suppose he didn't trust you when it mattered most. Catra isn't actually that good of a liar, you know. Consider it one of her many, *many* personal failures. Her deception only works on people who are already weak." Shadow Weaver took a generous swig of her rosé. "Still, I ought to commend you for having the courage to grab power where you saw an opportunity. How was it as Hordak's little pet princess? Is he as good in bed as the rumors say, or did Catra's cute little omnicidal temper tantrum happen before you could get past third base?"

"It… we… it's not like that," Entrapta stammered, sinking back into a nest of her hair. Yes, they were close, and Hordak had deferred to her as an equal, and *maybe* there had been a few tense nights

when she believed that her secret feelings for him might've been mutual, but none of that could possibly justify the way Shadow Weaver was talking about her. Or the way the princesses reacted.

"You were *sleeping with the enemy?!"*

"And you didn't tell *me?!* "

"What? You guys are just now figuring that out?"

Too many voices. Too many lights. Too many feelings.

Entrapta felt the parasite within her shift and move. It squeezed around her heart, triggering a dull ache that felt like her cardiac muscles were turning to stone. She wheezed out in pain, lifting her mask just enough to expel a nasty mass of blood clots and green mucus from her mouth, dotted with the tell-tale pale flecks of flower petals.

She slammed her mask back down to cover up her tear-streaked cheeks and flushed complexion, and escaped with her hair into the maze-like rafters of the Bright Moon castle.

Entrapta didn't know how long she was in her cozy little nook above the kitchen. Time meant nothing when her brain was trapped in limbo, overwhelmed with too many inputs to formulate any coherent output.

Eventually though, her brain rebooted just enough to catch bits of a conversation coming through the next room over.

"Who let you run around here without a muzzle and a babysitter?"

"Why, your lovely daughter, of course. She still has respect for her elders—a trait that you must have forgotten during your little island vacation, Micah."

“Maybe if you stopped grooming children to be your pawns, you’d be worthy of my respect. I see what you’ve been doing with Glimmer and Adora. You didn’t learn your lesson with me?”

“You turned out just fine.”

“Despite your best efforts. Have you already forgotten the last time we met?”

“It was nothing personal, Micah. Just the cost of doing business. Times have changed.”

“You never bothered to tell Glimmer *who* took her father away for seventeen years?”

An icy silence followed, then hushed mutterings that Entrapta couldn’t quite make out. Such a shame that she didn’t have Imp with her, the little spy was a master at eavesdropping and always seemed eager to share his data whenever she offered him candy (despite Hordak’s insistence that Imp refrain from consuming processed sugars).

The door between the kitchens and the hallway creaked open, and in came a figure with a nasty limp and bandages all up and down its limbs. It rummaged around the cabinets, unearthing a tinfoil-wrapped plate full of fluffy white buns, still steaming and warm. As the figure hunched over to unwrap its prize, the head swiveled to make a quick scan of the unlit and silent room, until its gaze rose to meet the princess lurking in the rafters.

Micah, the King-Father of Brightmoon, slowly bit down on the steaming bun in his mouth without breaking eye contact. “You too, huh?”

Entrapta said nothing.

“Old habits die hard,” he muttered around a mouthful of sweet dough. “You want some? I know you’re usually a fan of the smaller rations, but it’s hard to beat a fresh pork bun.”

The smell of warm bao made her mouth water and stomach churn. Maybe she wouldn't be able to keep it down, but it certainly seemed more appealing than anything else she'd been offered so far.

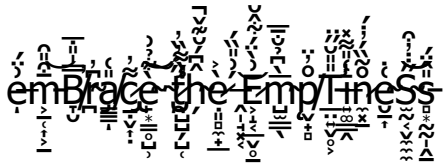
Purple tendrils slithered down from the rafters, delicately pulling a bun into tiny, bite-sized pieces. Entrapta stayed crouched up in her corner, but lifted her mask and started eating, one bite at a time.

The two Beast Island survivors stood in silence in the darkened kitchens, sharing a meal thirty feet apart.

"I overheard what Shadow Weaver said in the meeting room," Micah finally spoke up, finishing off his bao and grabbing another. "She has some gall, showing her face around here after everything she's done to hurt me, hurt Angella. Now she's sinking her teeth into Glimmer."

"Glimmer's lucky to have you back," Entrapta said, though it felt hollow coming from her mouth.

"I hope so." Micah stared off into empty darkness. "It's tough, isn't it? Trying to adjust to being home again, being safe and secure after spending so much time in a constant cycle of adrenaline and panic to survive. Trying to find your place in the world again, without—" his voice cracked, "—without your person. Without Angie."



Entrapta's heart lurched, but she managed to fight back against the pressure in her stomach to keep her few bites of food down.

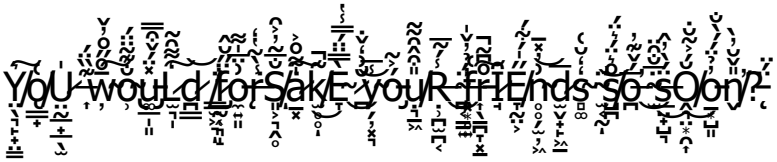
“I’m sorry for her loss,” she croaked out remorsefully. “If we hadn’t… the portal…”

“I understand what happened. You don’t need to apologize to me, I just wish…” he trailed off and let out a heavy sigh. “The best thing I can do is try to be there for Glimmer. And you—you’re just trying to go home, aren’t you?”

“I’m not sure where ‘home’ is anymore,” Entrapta confessed, “Just that it’s not here.”

Micah nodded. “Yeah, I don’t fault you for that. Whatever you need to do for yourself, do it. We’ll figure things out on our end.”

Her body fought back another cough, hacking up little chunks of dumpling and more of those hideous flower petals. Entrapta wasn’t entirely sure how much she bought into the so-called ‘healing power of love’ that Perfuma had insisted would cure her condition. For all she knew, it was already too late for her, and it would only be a matter of time before the blossoms and vines completely took over her airways and brought her life to a slow, suffocating, agonizing end. If she was already doomed, why shouldn’t she get to choose what to do with her body before the invasion was complete?



The princesses had been the ones who’d risked their lives to save her from Beast Island, not Hordak. They were the ones who believed she was in danger and brought her back to safety. They were the ones who’d believed in her as a trustworthy member of the alliance and invited her to participate in their tactical meetings, even after she’d spent so many months with “the enemy”. They were the ones who were trying to help her diagnose

and treat the parasitic disease consuming her body from the inside. They had taken so many risks to bring her here and keep her safe, didn't she owe them something?

And yet, her heart would not stop yearning to see *him* again, despite everything. Hordak hadn't investigated her disappearance, he hadn't trusted that she wouldn't leave him of her own volition without saying something. As vile as Shadow Weaver's words had been, there was a thread of truth to them that made it sting even worse than the lies and allegations. If their bond was as strong as Entrapta believed, why had he caved so easily to the deception?

What did it say about her, that she *still* wanted to choose to be with him, as the end was looming over her?

"What if what I need ends up hurting Glimmer and the other princesses?"

Micah stood again in silence, thoughtfully chewing on another pork bun. "I've been gone for seventeen years. That's seventeen years my daughter has grown up without me, fighting a war that never should have been hers to inherit. I think, between everything—the Horde, the Rebellion, and Angie's loss—she probably can't see that there might be a way out of this mess that spares lives on both sides."

"Do you really think that? That there's a way to end the war without one side completely destroying the other?"

"I don't know," Micah admitted. "The war's been going on for a lot longer than I ever hoped. I was a teenager when King Scorpio ceded power, and I never wanted the war to dominate Glimmer's generation in the way that it has. I can't help but hope, though, that there's a future where all of us—royals, sorcerers, civilians, beast folk, hordesmen, everybody—can work together to build a better Etheria. It'll take a lot of time and negotiation and sacrifice, but I want to believe. But what do I know?" He chuckled. "I'm just an old man eating in the dark, who's tired of fighting to survive."

Entrapta rose up from her little hidey-hole and disappeared across the rafters, her hair moving faster than her weakened limbs would allow, having made up her mind.

She didn't stop to talk to anybody else or gather any supplies. The only detour she made on the way out of the castle was to collect Emily from her charging station next to Scorpia's room, moving quickly and silently to avoid alerting anybody else.

Emily tried to excitedly greet her with a series of boops and beeps, but Entrapta hit a button to engage silent operation and put a gloved finger up to her lips. "Don't tell anybody, Emily. We're going home."

The robot and her beloved creator slipped undetected out of Bright Moon, en route to the one place in the world that felt more like home to Entrapta than Crypto Castle, the one place she'd felt free to fully be herself and be accepted, even with the bitter, painful memories that had ended her time there.

"Emily, set course for the Fright Zone."

Chapter End Notes

Fun fact: Perfuma's first suggestion when she first joined the princess alliance was to win over the Horde with a gift basket. If Scorpia had been the one in the Horde to receive it, it might've actually worked.

I use the title King-Father for Micah. Don't know if that's a thing, but it is here.

Also, I definitely subscribe to the head canon/fan theory that Shadow Weaver's the one responsible for sending Micah to Beast Island.

Death vine messages!

- Embrace the emptiness

- You would forsake your friends so soon?

This chapter was going to be longer, but then I hit almost 3k words and decided to split the rest into another chapter.
¯_(ツ)_/¯

Talking Politics

Chapter Summary

> The Princess Alliance wraps up in Entrapta's absence. Catra sends a warning. Hordak finally meets with his former partner.

Chapter Notes

> No smut yet, just a lot of angst ;)

The Princess alliance meeting was not going well. The room was still in an uproar in the aftermath of Entrapta's swift exit up into the rafters, and too many voices tried to shout over each other in a vicious competition to be heard. Somewhere in the chaos, Shadow Weaver disappeared.

Glimmer sulked in her throne. What the hell was wrong with everybody today? Adora kept giving her the stink-eye, Perfuma wouldn't shut up about gift baskets, and Mermista was yelling so loudly, thunderclaps could be heard booming from outside.

After a few fruitless minutes of trying to maintain order, the young Queen let out a frustrated groan and teleported on top of the table, stomping down hard and sending a shockwave of glitter flying up into everybody's faces.

"We are getting *off-topic,"* Glimmer shouted, balling her fists up like a petulant child as her fellow princesses choked on the cloud of sparkles. "Whatever's going on with Entrapta, we can deal with later. The point is—"

"—you're not even going to ask?" Scorpia choked out, fanning herself out of the cloud with a pincer. "You really don't care about what she's going through?"

"We all have our own shit we're dealing with."

Over the past year or so, Glimmer had been on the receiving end of Scorpia's frustration and anger many times during various standoffs between the Horde and the Princess Rebellion. The look of pure shock, disappointment, and genuine disgust that Scorpia now had on her face was an entirely new kind of disdain that Glimmer had never seen during any of their previous encounters as enemies.

"You were there. You saw how bad of a shape she was in just a few hours ago. Most of you were there!" Scorpia threw pointed gazes at Bow, Mermista, Frosta, Netossa, and Spinerella. "You all know something is very, very wrong, and yet nobody else except Perfuma and Adora have bothered to try to figure out *what* ."

"Then tell us!" Glimmer threw her arms up in exasperation. "If it's so important, why can't you tell us what you know?"

Scorpia sighed, and Glimmer felt something heavy settle in the pit of her stomach. "I've already broken her trust. It's her story to tell, and unlike *some people* I don't want to hurt her more by saying anything before she's ready. Honestly, I can see why she didn't think you guys would understand."

"Because of the whole 'Hordak' thing?"

This time, Adora snapped at Glimmer. "Seriously? You don't actually believe a single thing that comes out of Shadow Weaver's mouth? You don't remember all the lies she's told to hurt us? Everything she's done to try to split us apart?" Adora rose from her seat with a huff and made a beeline for the door. "That's what Shadow Weaver does, she sniffs out all of your deepest insecurities and makes you feel like you're worse than nothing for not being perfect. Entrapta doesn't deserve to be targeted like that. I'm going to check on her."

Scorpia was quick to follow, but not before throwing one more baleful glare at Glimmer. "Y'know, the whole reason I came here was because I thought you cared enough about Entrapta to help her. I guess I overestimated you."

Perfuma also made to leave after them, and Glimmer groaned. "Seriously, you too, Perfuma?"

"Sorry," Perfuma shouted back, in a sprightly tone that indicated she was not at all sorry for abandoning the meeting. "It's for TRUE LOVE!"

The plant princess threw her head back with that declaration as her battle cry, and the remaining alliance members sat awkwardly with only half their numbers remaining.

Finally, Queen Glimmer nudged her remaining best friend. "Can your datapad get a message out to the Horde?"

Bow raised an eyebrow. "Um, technically yeah, but it'll get intercepted by their general comms. If I want to cloak our message or get past their communications defenses, I'd need Entrapta's help."

"That's fine, I want them to know it's from us," Glimmer said, fighting back the nervous, fluttery feeling in her stomach. This could either be their ticket out of this shitty situation, or a death sentence. "Address the message to Lord Hordak. Tell him that we, in conjunction with Princess Entrapta, would like to request a temporary cease-fire to renegotiate the Horde's contract with Dryl."

"Are you sure this is going to work?"

Glimmer inhaled deeply. "Whatever's going on, I want to trust that Entrapta knows what she's doing."

With bated breath, Bow carefully composed the message and sent it out as dictated. Not even two minutes later, a message pinged back on his pad.

Bow glanced down at the message and squeaked out nervously. "Lord Hordak says he'll honor the cease-fire request for 48 hours, but only if he can talk to Entrapta directly. Nobody else."

"Well, that's a lot better than the 'fuck you' reply I was expecting," Mermista said, shrugging. "Maybe we have a shot at turning the tables, after all."

"Tell him it's a deal," Glimmer said.

Bow hesitated a moment before answering the message. "What if we can't find Entrapta and get her on board with the plan? I mean, it was her plan to begin with, but I don't know if she'd be okay with it if we initiated things without her."

"We'll figure something out, one way or another," Glimmer waved a hand dismissively. "At least this buys us another day or two."

Glimmer thought of Adora's glares and Scorpia's harsh disapproval, and hoped she was doing the right thing.

And just what on Etheria did Perfuma mean by "true love"?!

Entrapta was coming.

Lord Hordak stalked anxiously through his sanctum, obsessively reviewing the message that had been delivered to him an hour ago. After so many long, lonely nights spent without any sort of acknowledgement or apology (two hundred and eighty-three to be exact, not that he cared or anything) there was *finally* some sort of contact established.

Entrapta was ready to talk with him. Granted, it was about politics, but at this point he would take any chance he could get to hear her voice again, even if she hated him.

He'd spent the past hour on a rampage, finally tidying whatever was left of his sanctum to prepare for her arrival. Everything had

to be in complete order. He absolutely could not betray just how weak he had been in her absence, how it had physically pained him just to look at the portal remains because it reminded him so much of Entrapta: her brilliant smile, her intelligent eyes, her small, soft body huddled up underneath his…

No, absolutely not. There could be no sign of how deeply her betrayal had affected him, no admission of weakness or desperation, no matter how badly he wanted to sway her back to his side. He was Lord Hordak, scourge of Etheria and fearsome leader of the Horde!

And so, Hordak found himself castigating in front of a mirror, rehearsing all that he would say to the woman who had wormed her way into his cold, artificial heart, only to shatter it.

"You thought you could renege on our contract regarding the occupation of Dryl?"

Hordak stalked in front of the mirror, adjusting his scowl for maximum dramatic effect. No, no, that wasn't quite right. A devilish smile, perhaps? That felt a little more natural, but it'd be risky for Entrapta. There was the distinct possibility that it might accidentally become a genuine smile. Yes, a scowl would be best.

He scoffed theatrically, trying to bare as much of his fangs as possible. "I will not give up this territory so easily. I delivered on my end of the arrangement. I gave you access to the Horde's tech and the Black Garnet. I gave you preferential trade status and improved infrastructure. I gave you untold secrets of the wider universe, a position of authority within our ranks, nigh-unlimited resources to unleash your brilliant potential. I gave you my—" His throat closed up, even now, preaching to an audience that was composed solely of his reflection.

He'd given her his trust, his heart, his dreams and aspirations, anything and everything that made his miserable life on this desolate rock worth living. He'd very nearly given her his future, too, because as badly as he yearned to return home to Prime's

light, a happy life with Entrapta at his side had almost seemed worth staying for.

"I gave you a place at my side, as a partner," Hordak stuttered out. The reflection staring back at him was a quivering mess, blushing and desperate, with barely held tears already smudging his eyeliner.

Pathetic.

He had given her everything, and still she had chosen to leave him. What more could he possibly offer to convince her to come back?

The truth was, of course, there was nothing he could give that would make him worth her time and attention. She had seen his true colors, and rightfully understood that she would be better off without him. Deep in his heart, Hordak knew this, though it did not make the pain any easier to bear.

Even still, he had to keep a strong face. The Horde was closing in on the Rebellion, tenuous though their advantage may be, and it simply would not do to display any hint of weakness as they prepared for victory.

Catra decided this was an opportune time to storm in uninvited, just as he was sharpening the smudged edges of his eyeliner. "Sir, why have you called for a cease-fire? You're not actually taking the rebels seriously, are you?"

Hordak growled, throwing his picture-perfect scowl at her. "It is not your place to question my political decisions."

"It's got to be some sort of trick. We have them pinned, and they're scrambling around, looking for any kind of opening to strike."

"Precisely. It is your responsibility to ensure that we keep our advantage, even as I engage in these political matters. Or do you have so little faith in your commanding abilities that temporarily

halting our advances will bring the Horde to ruin?" Catra's eyes widened, and Hordak suppressed a smirk at her expense. "It is because of our advantage that I have full confidence in entertaining the Rebellion's little political game. Do not squander this opprotunity, Force Captain. I will meet with Entrapta–"

Catra's face blanched. "You don't need her for anything! Look at what you've done without her! What about Horde Prime? You're better off without her!"

"I need her!" Hordak bellowed, dropping his stoic facade. He stumbled back for a second, shocked at the sincerity of his own words. Catra's fur stood on end.

Hordak's brain stalled, trying to grasp for any sort of permissible explanation for his outburst. "...Data. I need her data," he muttered unconvincingly. "Yes, the only reason Prime's forces have not yet arrived is because of planetary interference. Since you have failed repeatedly to recover the data I require, I must consult the original source. I will acquire the information I need, by whatever means or force I deem necessary."

While intimidation was one of Hordak's finely-honed skills, deception was not. Omission and intimidation were considerably more effective methods of controlling information than the dissemination of lies. Hordak was not a liar, he did not tolerate lies being told against him, and his chest ached after having told several lies in one breath to Catra.

Hordak had not once considered why it was taking so long for Prime's forces to arrive, though they certainly would have had plenty of time to receive his signal and gather arms by now. His previous interest in recovering Entrapta's data had likewise not been motivated by any interest in reconstructing the portal, but by a desperate need to keep all traces of her presence close to him.

The most grievous of his lies was the insinuation that he would ever use force against Entrapta. He would rather risk his own life and limb to prevent any harm from befalling her, he could not

fathom being the perpetrator of that harm. The lie made him sick to his stomach as it left his mouth.

Catra encroached closer on him, her sharp eyes brimming with an emotion that Hordak couldn't place. His hand reached instinctively to shelter his power crystal—he had let his guard down around her in the past, he must not make that mistake again.

A faint shuffling noise echoed through the vents above them—Imp, no doubt. Hordak exhaled in relief knowing that, if Catra was bold enough to pounce on him again, his little spy was prepared to bear witness and assist, if needed.

Catra's ears perked, and her gaze bore straight into Hordak, like she was seeing right through to his soul. "Just remember, they'll do anything they can to weaken the Horde. Don't buy into their lies."

"Your concern is… noted, Force Captain."

With a final nod of acknowledgement, Catra exited the sanctum, finally giving Hordak enough space to breathe and reconstruct his domineering facade.

Power. He needed to exude power, to emulate the pomp and complete control embodied in the personage of Horde Prime. Hordak needed to evoke absolute strength to face off against the one person on the planet who understood his weaknesses so thoroughly.

The vent creaked open, and Hordak turned to send his little spy on another mission out of the sanctum. It was better to keep Imp occupied and out of the way as he prepared for the meeting with Entrapta. Imp had teased Hordak about his efforts to maintain a level head for her, and the boy would probably be so excited to see her again that he'd forget she was allied with their enemy.

As soon as Hordak saw who descended from the vents, his throat dried up, having miscalculated in assuming it was Imp lurking in the vents.

The mask was new. Large, bulbous, vacant eyes stared at him like an oversized insect. Her overalls were fitted a little differently too, pulled up to accentuate her bust in a way that he couldn't help but let his gaze linger on. What he could see of her skin was a little bit tanner, a little more scratched and scarred up.

But she was still Entrapta, even with everything that had changed during their separation.

She stared at him, her beautiful purple locks of hair still clinging to the vent above them, hanging down in front of him and fidgeting with her gloves.

Hordak cleared his throat and fumbled for words, having completely forgotten the entire script that he'd meticulously practiced. "Entrapta," He croaked, his tongue tripping over her name. "You look… erm, well."

Entrapta cocked her head, and he wished with all his heart that she'd drop the mask just so he could see her face again. "I heard what you said to Catra. Is that… really what you think of me?"

"Of course not!" He all but roared, his heart pounding furiously. "I would never allow any harm to befall you under my discretion!"

"Then why didn't you come for me?"

Hordak felt the heat take over his face and his senses leave him. Just being in the same room with Entrapta, hearing her voice, having her close enough to almost touch again was enough to completely shatter his ego. "I–I thought that you had realized how weak I truly am, how much happier you would be without me holding you back–"

"Why would you think that?" Entrapta shrieked, crossing her arms so tightly as if hugging herself. "The happiest I've ever been was

when I was with you! I never would have chosen to leave you!”

“Then why did you—?!”

“I was attacked!”

The mask flew off, and finally he saw Entrapta’s face for the first time in far too many months. Dark, puffy rings under her brilliant magenta eyes. Her plump, rosy lips were cracked and twisted into a grimace. Soft cheeks were sallow and thin, streaked with a mess of tears and mucus.

Hordak had been wrong. Entrapta did not look well, and from what it seemed, she had not been doing well for quite a long time.

He moved closer to her, daring to run his thumb along her cheek and see just how sunken it was up close. His other hand moved to her hip, hovering for a moment until she gave her approval with a slight nod, and his breath hitched as he realized how easy it was to feel her bones jutting from her skin.

“The princesses. They have been mistreating you,” He growled, with all the venom he could possibly muster. “I’ll make them pay. I’ll destroy them all.”

“No, not them. They’re not perfect, but they’ve been trying to help me,” Entrapta sniffled, bringing her hands up and around his neck to level with his face. “It was Catra. She attacked me and sent me to Beast Island.”

The two brain cells in Hordak’s head that were still capable of rational thought in Entrapta's presence finally kicked into gear. This whole thing with Entrapta suddenly coming back to him and being so receptive—it was too perfect to believe.

No, this was a trap. It had to be. What better way to sabotage the Horde on the cusp of victory than to tear apart the leader and its top commander with the feminine wiles of the most beautiful, brilliant princess this sorry planet had to offer?

Hordak released her forcefully, a little more roughly than intended, and immediately regretted the lack of contact with her. He turned his back on her to regain what little composure he could, but in the end, it was moot. Trap or not, Entrapta had thoroughly charmed him in the few minutes he'd been exposed to her company.

His chest tightened as he stalked around the room, trying to dispel the mental fog clouding his thoughts. "Is that what this is all about? Using your irresistible charm and powers of persuasion to weaken the Horde's leadership, under the guise of negotiating Dryl's status with the Horde, all so you and your *princess friends* could make a mockery of me?" He spat the words out in disgust, his shoulders quaking. Either with rage or desperation, he did not know.

Entrapta blinked in astonishment at his theatrics. "I came because I wanted to, Hordak. I'm not here for the Rebellion–"

"I am not an idiot, Entrapta! I know I am unworthy and impure. I know I have nothing to offer you. I am a failure–"

"SHUT UP!"

She towered over him, hair spread out everywhere along the ceiling like some magnificent goddess screaming at him from the heavens.

"I knew the portal was dangerous! I wanted to warn you! Catra attacked me from behind with a stun gun and shipped me off to Beast Island before I could shut it down!" Her chest heaved, like she was using all of her energy to get the words out as fast as was physically possible. "I was stuck out there for so long—two hundred and eighty-three days, Hordak. I counted. Two hundred and eighty-three days that I waited for help. And you never came for me. I wanted you to come, Hordak. I wanted to see you again, but you didn't believe in me. I had to wait for Scorpia and Adora and Glimmer and Bow to find me. Do you know what that's like, Hordak? When the person you love most doesn't come for you?

Do you know what that does to a person, the way that it eats at you from the inside, taking over your whole body until you can't eat or sleep or breathe? Like some kind of… horrible, terrifying, cannibalistic parasite."

Hordak was petrified.

He stared at Entrapta, at her wide, manic eyes and bony, bruised limbs, and his heart screamed at him that she was being completely truthful.

Thirty years ago, Hordak had emerged from a crashed spaceship on the shores of Etheria and stared with that same terrified, manic expression up at a starless sky, trapped and alone in a hostile environment, desperately hoping that Lord Prime would come for him.

He knew that pain intimately. And now, he had inflicted that same pain upon Entrapta, and worsened it with the power of his own stupidity.

Slowly, Hordak sank to his knees, falling prone before her.

"Forgive me," he croaked out, with his forehead pressed against the floor. "I did not… I could not fathom that one as brilliant as you would…"

A tendril of soft hair slithered up his neck, tugging at his collar to urge him upright. Gentle, delicate, gloved hands tilted his face up. Entrapta kneeled over him on the ground, using a strand of hair to wipe tears from her cheeks. "You stupid man, why is it so hard for you to believe that I actually love you?"

She fell into his arms and he held her close, trembling and crying like the lovestruck fool he was. "I have hurt you deeply with my ignorance and foolishness. I never should have doubted you, Entrapta. I'm sorry."

"I know," She smiled against his chest. "You used a contraction. You only do that when you're really worked up."

Hordak allowed himself to smile, finally. A genuine one, at that. He stroked his talons through her beautiful, silky hair and inhaled deeply, taking in the scent of her shampoo, the oil stains on her overalls, the worn leather of her gloves and sweat on her skin, all the little things that made her so deliciously *Entrapta.*

There was something else in her scent. Something sour and rotting that caught his attention, like the smell of a fungus or a decaying log. He narrowed his gaze and lowered his nose-stub closer to her face, trying to determine what exactly this strange, unpleasant source could be.

"Hordak," She muttered nervously, glancing sheepishly at him.

His right hand had been firmly planted on her thigh, holding her close to him. As soon as she moved, something *shifted* underneath his hand, twisting and spasming underneath the soft, sweet skin of her thigh. He slid his hand away, mouth hanging open in shock, as he realized her account of Beast Island had been far more literal than she'd let on.

"Entrapta, you're—"

Entrapta silenced him with a pigtail, gently booping his mouth closed. "Nothing's been right without you, Hordak," She confessed, her shoulders shaking under the force of a coughing fit. "It followed me from Beast Island and it won't let go of me. I've been trying so hard to fight it, but I'm so tired…"

Her body went limp in his arms, contorting in pain as the parasite invading her body took its control from her, crawling along her bones and crowding her airway. Entrapta was still breathing, albeit laboriously. He could hear her heart beating hard, like it was trying to pound against a force squeezing in on it.

As quickly as he could, Hordak gently twisted her hair into loops around his arm to avoid any trips or tangles and carried her urgently to his private quarters. The woman he loved so dearly was dying, and he would not fail her again.

Reconnecting

Chapter Summary

Two lab partners spend quality time together.

Chapter Notes

SMUT!! SMUT ALERT!!!

Explicit sexual content after the double line breaks, folks! These two have spent too much time apart and they are horny as hell.

A strange sort of calm came over Entrapta, even as her body was failing her. Being here again, with the soothing drone of heavy machinery, all the cozy little dark corners to creep in, the smell of plasma and the sensation of her partner's strong, armor-clad arms wrapping around her with a pleasant sort of pressure—all of it made her feel more comfortable and content than the fluffy pillows and tiny cupcakes in Bright Moon ever could.

Take away the whole 'deadly parasitic disease feasting on her innards' part, and Hordak's concern for her was downright adorable. He carried her like a proper princess down the secluded hall to his private quarters, moving swiftly with a very businesslike sense of purpose.

She'd been escorted this way before, during the handful of trysts that had instigated during those long nights spent working together in the sanctum. It was only ever meant to be a casual affair, a means of alleviating distractions and collecting data, but she had savored their shared intimacy all the same.

Entrapta was surprised when, instead of taking a left to his bedroom, Hordak went for the second door on the right to his maintenance room.

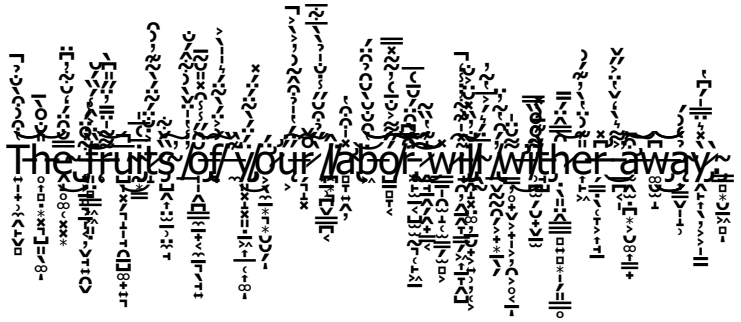
"What are we doing?" She asked, blinking up at him.

Hordak cleared the examination bench of various mechanical and medical tools, swiping them away with a careless motion of his arm and piling them onto the ground with a clatter. “We will locate, isolate, and extract the foreign body that is harming you. I will eliminate it. And then… er, we will proceed accordingly from there.”

The maintenance room was outfitted with everything an alien warlord with cybernetic life-support armor and a degenerative genetic condition could need to track the status of his body and keep his armor functional. It was just as sacred a space as his bedroom, if not more so, because this was where all the evidence of his greatest weakness was kept under heavy security. All of his private medical records and the details of the technology keeping him alive were here.

In any other context, Entrapta would be thrilled to be here. It was a gesture of his absolute trust in her, and an incomparable goldmine of data that would bring her one step closer to figuring out the enigma that was her lab partner.

As it was, Entrapta barely had the energy to sit upright, let alone raid his computer systems for medical data. She felt the panic rise in her throat as she watched him move about the room, flipping switches and manually re-calibrating the scanner machine to accommodate her much smaller frame.



Hordak's ears flattened as he watched her muscles tense up, and he slammed down anxiously at a keypad, as if hitting the buttons harder would speed up the process.

Entrapta looped a tendril of hair around his wrist, pulling him away from the console. Hordak didn't understand. For all the pain and frustration that he'd been through in trying to manage his own condition, he still didn't see just how dire her situation was. He was still scrambling around, trying to do what he could to help, when the odds were that it was already too late for her, and it had been for a long time.

She didn't have to pull very hard to bring him to her side. He came immediately, his brow furrowed in concern. She gripped his hand with both of hers, trying to anchor him to her, away from whatever image would appear on the scanner monitor.

"It's in too deep," She rasped hoarsely, on the verge of tears. "It's not just in one spot. It's everywhere."

He hunched over, bowing his head to her level and leaning in until their foreheads were nearly touching, piercing her heart with his fiery eyes and determination. "You have shown me incredible kindness and compassion in my hour of need. It is only logical that I return the favor, in whatever way I can. I know I have failed you, but please—" his voice cracked, "I can't bear to lose you again so soon."

Her grip loosened and he lingered, running his thumb over her knuckles. He breathed in as if to say something else, but abandoned his words and simply pressed his lips against her left temple, muttering something about completing calibration.

When it came time to strip down for the scanner, she used her hair to guide his hands to her fasteners. The overalls were easy, but he fumbled with the clasp on her purple sleeved top, leaving her only in her white undershirt and undergarments. There was nothing erotic in the way he helped her undress, but there was an intimacy to it all the same.

For some reason, she felt less distressed and vulnerable being exposed like this with him than she had felt while alone in her guest quarters in Bright Moon—quite a curious paradox. Maybe it was because there was finally someone else here to bear witness to the full extent of her damage.

Entrapta stayed as still as possible on the scanner bench as the machine whirred and the light swept over her. She kept her eyes pressed shut, partly to block out the light, but also to avoid seeing the images take shape on the monitor. She could tell just by feeling it how total the pathogen's control of her body was, but confirming it with visuals was too much for her to handle.

She heard Hordak sharply inhale as the imaging took shape, then silence. After what seemed to be an eternity, she felt his fingers intertwine with hers.

"I don't want to see it. Just tell me about it, I know it's bad," she whimpered out.

"The network is… extensive," he spoke in an even tone. "The density of the pathogen's protrusions makes it difficult to view many of your internal structures. Your brain, kidneys, and reproductive tract are all visible and clear of the pathogen. The greatest affected areas of concern are the spinal column, the cardiac and pleural regions, and the digestive tract."

"Lots of soft tissue damage."

"…yes."

"Too much to isolate and extract the pathogen."

Hordak was silent. Entrapta opened her eyes.

At first, she thought it looked like interference on the monitor. A million tiny, disorganized lines clouding the screen and preventing any clear images from displaying. As she got closer, she saw fractal patterns forming in the visual snow, tiny branches congregating and splitting apart and winding around every corner

and crevice of the displayed area. Roots and vines and blossom buds pushing through her body cavities.

Hordak was right, the chokehold on her organs was so complete, it was easier to determine which parts weren't affected than to try to discern which ones were. Everywhere she looked, there were vast clusters of roots and vines, digging into her viscera and shredding the fragile membranes of her lungs, her heart, her intestines and stomach—everything that it could take root in.

"We *will* find a way to fix this," Hordak muttered, "I won't let it take you from me. I can't." He moved to embrace her, enveloping her in his arms.

She burst into tears against his chest, heaving for breath. "It's not your decision to choose for me. I'm so tired of fighting it, Hordak. It's too late to make any difference."

"Then… What do you want? Anything I can do or give you, just tell me, and it is yours."

The earnestness in his voice was so apparent, it tore at her heart. What wouldn't he give her? Unfettered access to the Black Garnet? An end to the war? His passage home to Prime? Of course, she'd never ask him for any of those—except the runestone, maybe, but she'd rather share that privilege with Scorpia if given the chance.

No, there was only one thing she truly needed from him as her body was being overrun by the parasitic plant: the safety and intimacy that she'd so desperately craved for the past two hundred and eighty-something days.

Entrapta yanked his face down to meet hers and kissed him, gasping lightly as he reciprocated with an ardent moan. Her lips migrated down his jawline and neck, roaming around his skin with a carnal hunger that had not been satiated for several months.

"I've had a lot of time to think about what I want," she murmured against his jaw, "I don't want to *think* anymore. I just want to *feel*

you— on top of me, underneath me, inside and all around me."

His throat closed up as her fingers and lips skated up and down his neck, lighting him on fire with the sweetest touches he'd ever known.

"That's… a lot of prepositions," he croaked.

She claimed his lips for herself again, clumsily pushing into him as he braced himself against the bench. This man—her wonderful, hopeless, brilliant, idiotic, and beautifully imperfect lab partner—if the end was coming for her, there was no better way to die than in his embrace. And, by the stars, she would make the most of every second she had left with him.

Hordak grabbed at her, hands sliding up beneath her white undershirt, talons toying with the edge of her bra. He paused for a brief moment to give her a questioning look.

She hummed in his ear. "Do anything you want, just don't stop touching me."

"Anything?" A low growl erupted from his chest as he sliced through the undergarment, releasing the soft, pliable mounds of flesh from their restraints. "That's a dangerous power you've given me."

"I know, but it's one I want you to have." A lustful smile played at the edge of her lips, tempting him.

Massive hands kneaded away at her breasts, lightly grazing her nipples with the edges of his thumbs and eliciting soft mewls of delight. Every touch brought forth more beautiful music spilling from Entrapta's mouth, with the heat pooling between her thighs

and the tantalizing scent of her arousal beckoning him to drag his touch lower.

Hordak held himself back from immediately giving in to the siren's call. She'd granted permission to do anything he wanted, and all he wanted was to claim every inch of her body and make her fall apart with rapture under his touch.

Razor sharp teeth tore through her white top with ease, clearing the way for his tongue to drag along the sensitive skin of her neck, her chest, her belly. He nipped at her delicate golden skin, mapping out his path with shallow love-bites as she threaded her fingers in his hair, trying to pull him down to alleviate the ache in her core.

He stopped at her navel, working his way back up the trail with soft kisses. His right hand abandoned her breast to grab hold of her wrists and pin them against the bench, leaving her completely open for him. His mouth made its way over in a series of sloppy, open-mouthed kisses, his tongue prodding gently at her nipple. A fang scraped against the pert little peak, turning her soft mewling into an undignified squawk. Entrapta muffled herself with her hair.

Hordak growled, briefly removing his left hand from her chest to brush it away from her face. "My life has been far too quiet without your sweet keening echoing through these halls."

Her blush deepened, creeping down the beautiful swath of her neck and playing at the top of her chest. "You missed my voice?"

"More than you can imagine," he purred wistfully.

Hordak swapped hands, pinning her wrists with the left hand and freeing her other breast for his mouth to repeat the process, doubling down on her sensitive nipple and forcing even more hoarse squeals from his princess. He relished in the beautiful, shrill pitch of her voice—no longer did he need to contend with the scant few recordings he'd salvaged from her orphaned

belongings, not when he had the sweet instrument of his heart's desire here at his fingertips.

Entrapta flailed within his grip, squirming and panting as he blew lightly against her freshly licked breasts, sending a wave of goosebumps prickling her skin. Her head lolled back, hitting against the metal bench with an audible thud.

Hordak snapped up. He released her arms to cradle her head, his fiery eyes narrowing with concern. "Are you alright?"

"I can just… use my hair…" she grimaced, still shocked by the impact. "It'll be fine…keep going."

He scooped her up easily in one arm, caressing her face against his palm and kissing her sweet, plump lips. "No, you deserve all the finest comforts I can offer."

Hordak knew that his spartan sleeping quarters were devoid of the luxuries his beloved lab partner deserved, but it had provided adequate comfort for their past trysts, and it would certainly be better suited for their present needs than the metal bench of the maintenance room.

He carried her nearly bare body across the hall, savoring the feel of her skin. Her body betrayed countless bruises and bumps from the nightmarish ordeal she'd been through, but he was still hopelessly addicted to her.

Entrapta snorted with amusement as they entered his bedroom and he laid her gently on the bed. "You have *two* pillows? That's new!"

"Er… yes."

"And an extra blanket, too. You've been spoiling yourself without me around, huh?"

He pushed her against his two meager pillows, answering her with a deep kiss. "It is because of your influence that I have allowed

myself these extra comforts."

Their past trysts had been few and far between, much to his regret. He'd been reluctant to push for anything more between them, partly to avoid jeopardizing his reputation as a fearsome warlord, but more so to steel himself for his inevitable departure from Etheria. Sex was an experiment, but a relationship was a tether he could not afford to keep.

In the lonesome months he'd spent without her, he'd learned just how painfully intolerable his life was without the light and joy that Entrapta had brought him. Hordak had never known true companionship as equals until the day they became lab partners, and her absence had left a gaping wound in every place that mattered: in the lab, in the throne room, and in his bed.

He didn't want to admit that the second pillow had only been added in a poor attempt to replicate another warm body in his bed, something to cling to during the silent nocturnal hours when the loneliness ate away at his soul, taunting him for his failure.

Finally, Entrapta was in his bed again, grinning up at him in amusement and even more beautiful than ever before, despite her physically fragile state. Purple tendrils snaked around his limbs, playing with the clasps of his armor.

"Not yet," he snapped, swatting them away and kneeling over her on the bed.

Entrapta's brilliant pink eyes widened with curiosity. "No?"

"I'm not done with you, yet."

She squeaked out as he hoisted her adorable little socked feet over his shoulders, sliding his grip down to caress the ample flesh of her thighs. He inhaled deeply, taking in the tantalizing scent of her arousal soaking through the ratty fabric of her overwashed panties. Fangs sliced away at the scraps keeping her delectable mound hidden—they would not be missed.

Hordak was less patient in this position than he'd been while fondling her breasts. He dove into her with his long tongue, groaning in pleasure at her taste and sending waves of vibrations through her tight core.

The mewling returned, devolving into obscene moans of pure ecstasy as his fingers toyed with her clit. Clockwise, counter-clockwise, ravenously firm and unbearably light, the unpredictable stimulation of that precious bundle of nerves kept her on the edge without delivering relief.

His tongue buried into her, striking up against a sensitive rough spot deep within and forcing out a deep, wanton groan from his magnificent princess. He rubbed hard against her clit, and her thighs clamped around his neck so tightly, he might've been strangled if not for his armor.

Her back arched as her inner muscles constricted around his tongue, wailing in rapture as the orgasm rippled through her body. His tongue doubled its efforts, lapping mercilessly at her fluids like a starving man. Everything about her was addictive, from the sound of her keening to the smell of her arousal and the taste of her climax.

Her thighs never loosened while he continued to eat her out, but Hordak didn't care. He'd once believed that a death in the service of Prime would be the highest honor he could ever hope to achieve, but being suffocated by Entrapta's supple thighs while he brought her to endless bliss would be a far more pleasurable way to meet his end.

Entrapta was the living embodiment of everything that made his pitiful life worth living.

As soon as the first orgasm abated, his ceaseless ministrations sent her into another. And another. Her hair writhed about, clamping firmly onto his arms, and this time he did nothing to stop them. He was at her mercy just as much as she was at his,

and he was too entrapped within her essence to do anything against it.

…

Entrapta lay on his bed, flushed and panting, her legs still shaking from the aftershock of multiple orgasms.

That *tongue*— sweet son of a supernova, she hadn't realized just how easily that tongue of his could transform her into a quivering mess. Then again, they were breaking a dry spell that had lasted the better part of a year, so maybe it was inevitable that Hordak's restraint wouldn't last long.

As soon as her legs dropped from his shoulders, Hordak crawled up her body, burying his face into her neck. "Even the brightest of stars cannot compare to the way my heart burns for you."

Tears pricked at her eyes. Theorizing it based on evidence and observation was one thing. *Hearing* it straight from his mouth (especially a mouth that had just finished delivering multiple orgasms to her) was something else entirely, even if his feelings were cloaked in metaphor.

"You love me?"

He wiped the tears away with his thumb, planting kisses where they fell. "I love you, Entrapta. Every day without you at my side has been nothing more than misery. I will pay whatever penance I must to keep you with me, if you so choose."

"I wouldn't have come here if I didn't want you, too."

Hordak laughed at that, pulling her tighter against him like he was afraid she'd float away. Entrapta relaxed in his embrace, and became aware of yet another curious contradiction: sharing some of the control over her body with him made her feel more in control and empowered than she'd felt since the parasite had taken hold of her. It was her body, not the parasite's, and she

wanted to invite her wonderful, adorable, sexy lab partner to explore and touch and taste her.

At that moment, Entrapta felt something against her hip. For a split second, she panicked, fearing that the parasite was awakening again within her, rising up after lulling her into a false sense of comfort in her lover's embrace.

She shook off the panic upon realizing that the truth was far more benign: while she had been brought to ecstasy multiple times already, Hordak's member was fully aroused and eager for release.

The parasite, meanwhile, was suspiciously quiet.

Entrapta, filled with a sudden burst of energy, decided to take advantage of the lull in activity and hoisted onto her partner, straddling his waist.

"It's your turn," she rasped, though her lungs didn't hurt nearly as much as they had earlier in the evening.

His ears flicked down. "I—I can take care of myself, your comfort comes foremost—"

She booped his mouth closed with a pigtail. "Hordak, I want this. I've wanted this for so long. If you're not ready, we can talk about it, but I meant it when I said all those prepositions earlier. All. Of. Them."

A dark glint appeared in his burning red eyes, and he shifted to push aside his tabard. Purple tendrils swept across his body with precise movements, working at the clasps of his armor to speed the process along. The parts were delicately scattered around the bedroom floor. They'd have time to set everything right later, but right now, her focus was on him.

She hovered over him with a playful smirk, tenderly grasping his shaft and pumping a few times, just for good measure. He squirmed and panted at her touch, and she couldn't help but

cackle with all the love in her heart at how the big bad warlord of the Fright Zone was so easily tamed by her touch. *She* did this to him.

A low, wanton groan erupted from his chest like rolling thunder, a deep and unbelievably erotic timbre that echoed through her very soul.

" *Entrapta.* "

Oh. Oh yes, please, she could happily accept her fate and submit to oblivion, if only he'd say *her* name in *that* voice, ad infinitum.

" *I need you."*

She answered his plea with a needy whine, positioning herself over his eager cock. His talons dug into the plump flesh of her backside as she maneuvered herself, adding fresh scars to the count on her body, though these were ones she could look back on with pride instead of pain.

Too many months had passed since they'd come together like this, she hissed a bit as the tapered head slowly pushed forward. He rocked his hips forward, and he started to fill her aching core, rocking slowly in careful, almost lazy motions to let her body readjust to his presence.

And—oh, it felt so *right,* like a bolt slamming into its rightful place. Every inch of him filled her completely, every ridge of his cock massaged her inner walls just right, every movement of his body fell in tandem with hers.

Her head fell back with a deep, throaty moan as he snapped his hips.

Yes.

This was what she'd missed this whole time, the overwhelming sensation of warm bodies and hot breath intermingling in a passionate display of pure, frantic energy.

Entrapta didn't want to be some grotesque meat-puppet controlled from the inside by a parasitic nightmare plant from the depths of hell. No, she wanted to be alive and free, to love and learn and feel and forgive and savor all the wonderful things that the world had to offer, like bite-sized cupcakes with rainbow sprinkles, disco balls that shoot lasers, and a partner who rips the clothes off her body with his teeth and made her feel so loved and wanted: a million little things that she wasn't ready to let go of.

She never wanted to let go of him.

Somewhere in their rhythm, she slouched forward to pepper his chest with kisses while he thrusted into her, grabbing at his flanks and burying into him. All she wanted was to feel him, all of him, everywhere.

His breathing became ragged and movements more erratic as she curled into him. He was getting close, she could feel it on his breath.

"Come for me," she whispered huskily into his chest.

"Not before you," he mustered out half-coherently.

Before she could say anything else, he pulled out of her completely, twisted her huddled body around, and entered her again from behind, lavishing kisses and sweet caresses all over the scarred skin of her back and sending her howling in pleasure from the new position.

His deft fingers worked at her clit, pushing her over the edge yet again as wave after wave of pure euphoria overwhelmed her. Hordak cried out in a deliciously undignified moan as her core contracted around him and sent him reeling, spilling into her with the product of his lust and love for her.

After several long, bliss-filled moments of connection, they rolled apart, still flushed and basking in the aftershocks of ecstasy.

Hordak took her hand and kissed it, placing it over his heart. "Anything I have to do to keep you with me, I will. You are everything to me, Entrapta."

She sniffed, choking on the stinging sensation of impending tears. "I want to stay with you, too, Hordak. I love you so much."

He held her tight to his chest, draping both blankets around them, and she closed her eyes in true relaxation for the first time in two hundred and eighty three days, listening to the soft, rhythmic whirring of his mechanical heartbeat.

Life Worth Singing

Chapter Summary

> After being happily reunited, Entrapta and Hordak take stock of their situation and plan their next steps forward, together.

Chapter Notes

> Here we are, folks! I think this is a good spot to mention that this whole story is inspired by a few things: the "flowers" prompt for the Entrapdak positivity month a little while back, some very fun discussions on Discord, and the music of Emezie Okorafor, especially the songs "Rock Opera", "Apoptosis", and "Life Worth Singing". It's a phenomenal combo of heartfelt, angsty, and life-affirming that I 1000% recommend checking out.
>
> Content warning for vomiting, discussion of Entrapta's barely repressed PTSD, and naked cuddling, but nothing spicier than that.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was not the sound of the parasite's incessant whispering that woke Entrapta, nor was it sudden jolts of pain running along her spine, a burning sensation in her throat and chest, or an unbearably nauseating feeling of her stomach being flipped inside-out. All of these had plagued her since the parasite had taken hold of her, interrupting the few hours she'd been able to rest.

No, the thing that woke Entrapta was an alert ringing on one of Hordak's consoles.

Hordak shifted out of the bed with a grumble, slammed down on a keypad to silence the alarm, then returned back to wrap his arms around her in bed. "Pay it no attention, I gave my force captains advance notice to postpone our usual meetings. I suppose someone missed the memo."

She sat up, blinking blearily, resting up against his broad frame, her hair wrapping around to cocoon them together. It felt like a dream, with all the confessions and apologies and tender caresses. There had been few nights during their months apart that she'd been rested enough to dream, but the few dreams she'd had nearly always centered on him.

Touching her. Tasting her. Stabbing her in the back.

Last night had pushed all of those desperation-fueled wet dreams and terrifying nightmares to the deepest part of her memory, where they could be safely kept locked away with the rest of her recent traumas.

Hordak missed her. He needed her. He loved her. He'd chosen to stay with her instead of overseeing his army claim victory over the rebellion. He'd apologized, and he was eager to continue finding ways to make it up to her and support her. Nothing could erase the months of torment she'd experienced or the damage done to her body and psyche, but right now, she felt *safe* enough to finally start the process of healing.

She buried into his chest with a contented groan, lazily taking in his presence—the warmth of his skin, the smell of his standardized Horde-issued soap, the soft whirring of his mechanical heartbeat. "How'd you know I was coming, anyway?"

He buried his face into her hair. "Did you not send the message out from the alliance requesting an audience to discuss the occupation of Dryl?"

"It was my proposal at our alliance meeting to reach out to you, but… it didn't go well. I think they were too scandalized by the idea and fixated on their own prejudices to really listen to me."

He grumbled in disapproval. "Perhaps eventually they saw fit to trust in your judgment, as they ought to have from the beginning. They are fools to have ever disregarded your brilliance and boundless compassion."

Entrapta pondered this, snuggling back into the embrace of her lover. As grateful as she was that Scorpia and Glimmer and the rest had come to rescue her from Beast Island, she hadn't felt very welcome among their ranks at all. The whole ordeal had reminded her of why she'd stayed behind in the Fright Zone in the first place, even before she'd become emotionally entangled with Hordak.

Hordak was right, though: they *had* listened to her in the end, even though it didn't excuse the way they'd treated her. And Scorpia had seemed sincere in her efforts to try to be a better friend, along with Adora (and even Perfuma, too, to her surprise).

No, it did not fix the problems that left her feeling ostracized and targeted by their social group, but all of this added up together to provide her some hope that maybe, just maybe, there might be enough good will for some sort of reconciliation in the coming days.

She noticed a datapad tucked in his side of the bed with some fascinating blueprints and graphs. She reached for it with her hair, immediately curious. "What's this?"

Hordak's face flushed bright red and he fumbled for the tablet, but she kept it out of his grip. "It—er, while you were resting, I thought that it might be prudent to design an assistive medical device to provide extra support to your body and aid in recovery. If you approve, of course."

It was a schematic for a set of armor, Entrapta-sized, with a nearly identical power crystal set at the neck. The notes were written in two different fonts, with one set being more general specifications and the other seeming to focus on providing medical support to the internal organs that had been affected most harshly by the parasite.

The blueprints seemed awfully detailed and complete to have been drawn up in a few short hours. Had he started work on this before their separation, or maybe even during? Perhaps someday,

he'd admit to one or the other, but what mattered most was that he *had* been thinking about her, and was considerate enough to update the plans to better suit her present needs.

Entrapta's fingers tapped in excitement as her finely-honed analytical mind processed the schematics, eager to jump into action and start on this promising new science project that her wonderful lab partner had designed solely with her in mind.

"I love it already," Entrapta grinned, kissing him lightly on his blushing cheek.

The alert went off for a second time, and again Hordak got up with a snarl to shut the damn thing off. "Idiots. Do they not understand I am *busy?!"*

Entrapta cackled, but her glee was halted with a sudden wave of nausea. She made a mad dash for the humble bathroom attached to his sleeping quarters and deposited the few contents of her stomach into the sink, heaving and choking on the bile.

Hordak ran to her side in a few swift strides. His talons raked through her hair and held it back from her face while his free hand prepared a wet cloth for her forehead. He murmured quiet words of support, his countenance completely changing from irate to tender in the span of a heartbeat.

The contents were lighter and more translucent, as opposed to the darker color indicative of internal bleeding. There was more plant matter in the mess, but it was like an entire chunk had sloughed off from the pathogen. There were roots in this one that were curled in on themselves, and pale blossoms that were browning.

The parasite was dying, its flowers withering away and roots losing their grip on her organs, enough for her body to begin the tedious, painful process of expelling the pathogen from her system and healing.

It was disgusting and painful, and she hunched over the sink with pride gleaming in her eyes. "I lived, bitch." She laughed hoarsely, her throat still sore from the bile. "Adequate concentration of serotonin and oxytocin… maybe there is something to this 'healing power of true love' thing."

Hordak stooped down, nuzzling into her neck and savoring her scent. "Perhaps, just to be safe, we should engage in another round of treatment."

She rinsed her mouth out crudely with a hair-hand-scoop of water and moved to kiss him, pressing her still-naked body flush against his. He moaned lightly, either not noticing or not caring about the lingering taste of bile and plant matter in her mouth, so long as Entrapta was his, and his alone.

The alert rang out for a third time.

Hordak growled out in frustration and stormed over to the console, hastily tugging on his discarded tabard and arm gauntlets to quickly muster a somewhat passable appearance. He slammed down forcefully on the console, televising his enraged image to whoever had the gall to interrupt him *three times* after explicit instructions not to.

"What? What is the meaning of this incessant interruption?!" Hordak boomed out, his eyes blazing with pure fury.

Commander Grizzlor was slumped against the wall just outside Loading Bay 3, rubbing the back of his neck sheepishly. "Apologies, sir, but there's been a breach. We have three intruders from the princess rebellion who claim to have 'gone rogue' and they're causing all sorts of problems for us—former force captain Scorpia, former force captain Adora, and the annoying blonde one with the flowers."

Several loud crashes could be heard from somewhere off-screen.

Hordak gritted his teeth. "And why, pray tell, have you not incapacitated them?"

“It was an ambush, sir. Scorpia got me good before I knew what was going on. I’ve only just regained the feeling in my arms a few minutes ago.”

A faint voice could be heard calling out from the camera feed. “I’m sorry, Commander Grizz! It’s nothing personal, we’re on a mission for love!”

Entrapta lurked in the bedroom behind Hordak, trying to stay out of the camera frame. He’d installed the security/video console in his bedroom years ago to allow him to project his image and communicate nearly anywhere in the Fright Zone on days when his pain left him bedridden, though such days had been rare ever since Entrapta had developed and installed his upgraded armor.

Emily had a spare change of clothes in her storage compartment, though she’d been left patrolling just outside of Hordak’s sanctum. In the meanwhile, Entrapta took one of Hordak’s blankets and wrapped it loosely around her shoulders, just enough so that she wouldn’t accidentally flash the entire Fright Zone (as hilarious as that would be) while Hordak flipped through the camera feeds in search of the rogue princesses.

The halls were cluttered with greenery, massive vines and trees sprouting forth from the dingy metal walls, trapping soldiers and blocking off doorways. A couple of security drones were scattered about in pieces, though Entrapta took note that all the damage was mostly external, just to incapacitate and disarm them, and they’d likely be salvageable.

They finally found the intruders in the cafeteria in the east wing, just a few halls away from the Sanctum. Adora was in her full transformation, delivering a single well-aimed slice of her blade to incapacitate another security drone. Scorpia was battling against several Horde officers in varying amounts of armor, apologizing profusely for interrupting their meal period. Perfuma stood on a wave of greenery, dominating the room with thick ropes of vines and leaves and spreading flower petals everywhere she went.

Scorpia noticed Hordak's face on the security screen in the cafeteria and gaped at it just long enough for one of the Horde officers to try to grapple her. She threw them off easily without looking away from the screen. "Oh! Hi there, Lord Hordak, sir! Wait, do I still have to call you 'sir', even though I technically left the Horde? Actually—nevermind, we come in peace! Mostly!"

Hordak raised a brow at the commotion. "This is your definition of 'peace'?"

"We're on a mission in the name of TRUE LOVE!" Perfuma cried out, throwing her head back and releasing a cloud of spores and rose petals that dropped several of the unhelmeted Horde officers to the ground, unconscious. "Entrapta is in terrible danger, and we believe you're the only one who can save her from becoming a really sad and cosmically disharmonious tree!"

Hordak brought a fist up to his mouth and coughed, trying to hide the sudden blushing of his face. "…I, erm, acknowledge your concern for the monarch of Dryl. However—"

Entrapta bounced into frame behind him and ruffled his hair playfully. "Hi, girls! I'm here, and I'm definitely not a tree, I'm doing just fine! You guys can stop making a ruckus, I think it's stressing Hordak out."

All three of the rogue princesses clambered toward the monitor, relief washing over their faces.

Adora took center stage, waving awkwardly at the two lab partners through the screen. "Sorry for making such a mess, we wanted to do everything we could to try and make sure you were okay. You're our friend, and we just wanted to help." Adora halted, her eyes staring wide at the screen. She blinked rapidly. "I'm sorry, are you naked? Is this a bad time?"

Entrapta drew the blanket around her closer. "No. I'm wearing socks."

Scorpia pushed forward, filling the screen's entire field of view with an uncomfortable close-up of the right side of her face. "Ohmigosh Entrapta, your skin is GLOWING!! Are you feeling any better? Is he treating you right, or do you need us to gently persuade him with a bit of hand-to-claw combat?"

"I brought a gift basket! Just in case we needed a bit of extra leverage to convince him to help," Perfuma beamed. "I don't know exactly what Lord Hordak's tastes are, but it's hard to go wrong with vegan chocolate cookies and fancy soaps!"

The two lab partners exchanged a look. Entrapta smiled awkwardly. "Thanks for looking out for me, but we've actually got things covered now. I don't think any of all that's really necessary. Except the gift basket! You can leave that. I could really use a snack."

Hordak cleared his throat. "Perhaps, if you can assist in the arrest of my *former* lead commander Catra and surrender her to our custody, we may be more amenable to further negotiations with the Princess Alliance."

The three rogue princesses huddled together for a moment, consulting each other. Perfuma was the most eager to comply with Hordak's suggestion if it would open the door for diplomatic intervention, but Adora and Scorpia each seemed to harbor reservations about arresting Catra.

Adora raised her head to address Hordak once more. "If we arrest Catra for you, are you going to kill her?"

Entrapta shifted uncomfortably, and Hordak reached to hold her hand, glancing at her with a silent question in his soulful eyes. For all the pain and suffering that she'd been subjected to as a result of Catra's cruelty toward her, she did not want to have that blood on her hands. Maybe later, when Entrapta was in a better headspace to process the trauma, she and Hordak would be able to come up with a just punishment for the traitorous cat, but right

now she'd be content just having Catra in custody to give herself the space she needed to heal and grow.

"No," Entrapta declared with unwavering confidence, "We'll just keep her in custody for the time being until we can agree on a proper sentence for her. Her violent behavior against me was an act of impulse, and I will not inflict an impulsive punishment against her in return."

Hordak caressed her hand gently, his expression toward her softening with pure love and adoration. "I trust Entrapta's judgment, especially considering that she has been personally victimized by the former lead commander. You have my word that Catra will remain alive in our custody, for the time being."

It was the most merciful treatment they could promise to the trio of princesses, and Adora and Scorpia seemed convinced enough of Hordak's word that they agreed to the request, slipping out of the cafeteria to hunt down and arrest Catra. Perfuma did, in fact, leave the gift basket of vegan chocolate cookies and fancy soaps behind, squarely in frame of the camera where it could easily be seen and retrieved as a small peace offering for the happy couple.

The camera feed cut to black, and Hordak turned back to his beloved princess with a sultry gaze.

"Now then, I do believe we were interrupted?"

Entrapta lept at him with vigor, dropping her blanket, smothering him with sweet kisses, and stripping away at his tabard, once again.

It was the first day of the rest of her life, and all she wanted was to spend it with him, basking in their love.

Chapter End Notes

> Hordak was absolutely making plans for Entrapta's armor set pre-portal meltdown. A step up from "technologically sound" as a thank-you gift, y'know? Matching couples' outfits!

I might add a more comprehensive epilogue in the future about peace negotiations between the Horde and the Rebellion, repairing the relationships between Entrapta and the other princesses, Catra's sentencing and Shadow Weaver's eventual fate, but I feel pretty confident in leaving things here for now, with Entrapta and Hordak happily reunited and on the path to healing, and the door open for a relatively bloodless resolution for both sides of the war.

Thanks to everybody for joining me on this ride, and I hope it was as fun to read as it was for me to write!

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